

Drug bust signals complex ring, experts say

Advanced methods, high volume of cocaine cited in case of ex-aide of Healey

By Stephanie Ebbert and Tricia L. Nadolny
GLOBE STAFF

The hefty parcel of cocaine intercepted by drug authorities in October en route to Springfield would have made headlines even if it hadn't been addressed to the governor's office.

Weighing in at 7.8 kilos, or 17

pounds, it was a significant bust for authorities. The drugs were worth potentially \$300,000 on the street and would mean a mandatory minimum sentence of 12 years in state prison for anyone convicted of trafficking them. What's more, authorities linked the delivery to another 27 pounds of cocaine shipped by UPS to the loading dock of a nearby hotel

and similar suspicious parcels sent in previous weeks.

Authorities believe the intended recipient was LaMar Cook, the 45-year-old deputy director of the governor's Western Massachusetts office. He has been charged with cocaine trafficking.

All told, the deliveries add up to what authorities suspect were more than 100 pounds of cocaine within a few weeks.

Experts said no rookie or low-level player would be receiving drug deliveries of that magnitude and frequency.

"Your first shipment is not eight kilos," said Nathaniel Mendell, a longtime former federal prosecutor who served as acting US attorney in Boston in 2021 and 2022. "And your first shipment is not to a loading dock that you can go check when you get around to it. You do that after you have a system that's been tested and worked out. You build up to that."

COOK, Page A10

Judge rebukes prosecutor of Comey

Cites apparent errors, hints at possible misconduct before recent grand jury

By Alan Feuer
NEW YORK TIMES

A federal magistrate judge said Monday that the criminal case against former FBI director James Comey could be in trouble because of a series of apparent errors committed in front of the grand jury by Lindsey Halligan, the inexperienced prosecutor picked by President Trump to oversee the matter.

The remarkable rebuke of Halligan came in a 24-page ruling in which the magistrate judge, William E. Fitzpatrick, ordered her to give Comey's lawyers all of the grand jury materials she used to obtain the indictment and raised the question of whether "government misconduct" in the case might require dismissing the charges altogether.

In his ruling, Fitzpatrick said that when Halligan appeared — by herself — in front of the grand jury in September to seek an indictment accusing Comey of lying to and obstructing Congress in 2020 testimony, she made at least two "fundamental and highly prejudicial" misstatements of the law. He also pointed out that the grand jury materials he ordered her to turn over to him for his review this month appeared to be incomplete and "likely do not reflect the full proceedings."

COMNEY, Page A4

Trump renews Obamacare repeal effort

Yet with subsidies expiring, no backup has been offered

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Now that the government shutdown is over, the clock is ticking on the issue that helped spark it: the expiration of enhanced tax credits for Obamacare health insurance on Dec. 31 that will trigger massive increases in premiums for millions of Americans.

But that effort is morphing into a broader fight over the fate of the 2010 law itself, which is loathed by many congressional Republicans and, especially, President Trump. If this battle sounds familiar, that's because crafting an alternative health care plan has become the GOP's white whale.

And after 15 years, Republicans still don't have one.

"They've got nothing. They've never had anything," said Representative Zoe Lofgren, a California Democrat who helped pass the law, officially

HEALTH CARE, Page A5

For people striving to break into the middle class, hard work is no longer enough

By **Katie Johnston** | Globe Staff



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

'Financially it's really terrifying. ...

There's no security in anything.'

Kayla Ortiz

Kayla Ortiz was 10 and already in foster care when her mother died. She cycled through homes and residential schools, packing her belongings in garbage bags as she went.

SQUEEZED After aging out of the system, Ortiz floated between the homes of family members who struggled with alcohol and mental illness, and she was homeless for a while, couch-surfing in friends' living rooms. She got into abusive relationships, ruined her credit trying to survive, and had three children in her 20s.

But along the way, she slowly started lifting herself up. She took classes at MassBay Community College in Framingham, where she worked at the bookstore full time, alongside a bookkeeping gig. She became a social worker — helping teen moms, people dealing with mental illness, and families living in shelters. And she sought out resources, including the Jeremiah Program, which supports single mothers in poverty.

Today, she is 33, living in an income-restricted apartment in the Seaport and working in the Mayor's Office of Housing. Her bachelor's degree is just a few classes away.

Ortiz has worked mightily to dig herself out of a hole, and she is on the

STRIVING, Page A6

Farren Bassett played on the monkey bars outside her home in Barre as her parents, Ben and Litani, watched. The bars once stood at Ben's elementary school, where he used to play on them as a child.

In the news

School leaders in Boston proposed adding two high schools and an elementary school to their plan to shrink the district as enrollment falls. B1.

The State Police discriminated against female and minority troopers, a jury found. It said the agency should pay at least \$6.8 million to the plaintiffs. B1.

Former Harvard University president Larry Summers will step back from his public commitments, saying he is ashamed after being criticized for his ties to disgraced financier Jeffrey Epstein. **A2.**

Saboteurs tried to destroy a train in eastern Poland on a vital line for delivering aid to Ukraine, Polish leaders said. **A3.**

Let it snow, let it snow, let it snow — New Hampshire's ski season began with Black Mountain's earliest first day in nine-plus decades. **D1.**

A feast, with a few choice fixins'

Facebook philosopher talks turkey about the right way to celebrate

By Beth Teitell
GLOBE STAFF

NEWTON — Many people have strong feelings about how Thanksgiving should go down, but in 2008, in Newton, one man, a now-retired health care tech startup guy, decided to do something about it.

Kim Suga, 59, is not a chef, a therapist, or any kind of expert, unless you count the kind who's lived long enough to know how a family can tear itself apart over yams. But for nearly 20 years, he's taken to Facebook to issue a list of holiday rules and "gentle" suggestions (with "gentle" in the eye of the insulted relative, but more on this later).

The list was born of unhappiness with a long-ago host's approach to the holiday — heck, Suga couldn't even watch football on TV — and at this point, the best way to describe it is Larry David meets Martha Stewart, with a pinch of "South Park."

Don't serve dinner before 3 p.m. It's pure savagery.



BEN PENNINGTON FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Kim Suga kept an eye on his pet chickens at his Newton home earlier this month. He also keeps track of holiday rules, enforced with "gentle" suggestions.

Regarding stuffing: Zero nuts or fruit. On this, there can be no negotiation. Vegans/vegetarians/special diet downs: Bring your own atrocious, wretched food.

The list is alternately funny, heartfelt, and self-righteous, and clocking in at over 30 entries, it manages to nail basically every Thanksgiving tradition.

THANKSGIVING, Page A10



Cool beams

Tuesday: Breezy, some sun. High 45-50, low 31-36.

Wednesday: More sun. High 45-50, low 33-38.

Sunrise: 6:39. Sunset: 4:19.

Weather and comics, **D5-6.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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